

Chapter 3 — Ethical decision-making

When utility, rights, fairness

Learning objectives

- Describe utilitarian, rights-based, virtue
- Justice reasoning
- Explain why stakeholder review belongs before locking thresholds or sharing defaults

Four lenses for data work

- It formalizes the utility–privacy tension from Section 3.2
- Rights-based reasoning holds that autonomy, privacy
- Virtue ethics asks what an honest, fair
- Justice reasoning inspects whether burdens fall disproportionately on already

Example 3.29 — Healthcare prediction

- Example 3.29 — hands-on module
- Even when individuals did not consent to research reuse
- Which is why rights-based checks are needed in parallel
- Explore the chapter example module
- View files: ``modules/chapter3/example29/``

Rights, virtue, and justice vignettes

- Duties rather than optional costs
- Virtue ethics may require disclosing systematic label gaps rather than selling cleaner
- Justice reasoning may delay hiring ranker launch until subgroup audits show disparities

Example 3.33 — User data collection for marketing

- Example 3.33 — hands-on module
- Example 3.33 applies all four lenses to marketing collection under a vague notice
- Utilitarian views emphasize engagement gains
- Explore the chapter example module
- View files: ``modules/chapter3/example33/``

Example 3.34 — AI in criminal justice

- Example 3.34 — hands-on module
- Example 3.34 returns to recidivism and hotspot conflicts from earlier in the chapter
- A model may improve average institutional metrics while concentrating harm on already
- Justice criteria that inspect subgroup harms, not citywide averages alone
- View files: ``modules/chapter3/example34/``

Stakeholder involvement

- Section 3.1 and Example 3.1 named practitioners, leaders, policymakers, and data subjects
- Decision-making adds a process requirement
- Document who was consulted, which lens prevailed

Takeaways

- No single lens dissolves every conflict, teams should apply several deliberately
- Stakeholder review surfaces residual risks a single product owner may miss
- Accountability requires a record of the choice, not only the shipped feature

Next

- Complete the quiz for this part
- Continue to the final part on emerging trends, AI surveillance, global regulation friction